

Indiana - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	National-title contender and top-10 roster/team projection.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 6 (1440 points, 8 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 5
Returning production	60% (No. 35) overall · Off. 54% (No. 71) · Def. 66% (No. 13)
Primer power rating	+26.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.0 wins · most likely 10-2
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse than an extraordinary 16-0 peak, but still elite nationally
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Indiana should still look like Curt Cignetti's balanced, presentation-multiple offense with Mike Shanahan calling plays, now built around QB Josh Hoover, WR Charlie Becker/WR Nick Marsh and a highly regarded returning OL core.

Bottom line: Indiana remains a playoff/title contender, but QB Josh Hoover and a large replacement class must sustain a top-five profile after heavy NFL losses.

Beats expectations if: QB Josh Hoover is efficient, the veteran OL stays elite and DC Bryant Haines preserves havoc/disguise through heavy turnover.

Disappoints if: Passing efficiency falls, the rebuilt secondary loses communication and the departure volume creates more inconsistency than top-five models expect.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** Indiana's 2025 dominance was fully supported by advanced metrics: adjusted offense No.2, adjusted defense No.3, offensive EPA No.1 and havoc created No.1.
- National baseline:** The 2026 consensus still treats Indiana as elite: SP+ No.5 (+25.8), AP No.6 and 10.0 projected wins.
- Coaching:** QB Josh Hoover is the established projected QB1 and Mike Shanahan is the offensive play-caller, preserving more offensive structure than the No.1-pick QB departure alone suggests.
- NFL departures:** Indiana lost 15 significant players to professional football, including eight NFL draft picks, so this is an elite reload rather than a continuity-heavy repeat roster.
- ★ **Preseason recognition:** The strongest returning spine is OL/LB: OL Carter Smith and OL Bray Lynch carry major recognition, while LB Rolijah Hardy and LB Isaiah Jones return as decorated linebackers.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	16-0 (11-0 Big Ten)	● Excellent
Scoring	41.6 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	452.0 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	212.9 YPG · 5.2 YPC	● Elite
Pass efficiency	9.42 YPA · 46 TD / 7 INT	● Elite
Third downs	56.5%	● Elite
Scoring defense	11.7 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	266.0 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	77.2 YPG · 3.0 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	188.8 YPG · 6.20 YPA · 10 TD allowed	● Elite

Indiana was elite in 2025: offense ranked No. 3 in scoring and No. 1 in pass efficiency/third downs, while defense ranked No. 2 in scoring.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+13.02 · No. 2	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.293 · No. 1	● Elite
Off. success rate	54.8% · No. 2	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	14.4% · No. 21	● Very good
Havoc allowed	11.6% · No. 11	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+12.00 · No. 3	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.261 · No. 4	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	33.2% · No. 5	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	7.5% · No. 6	● Elite
Havoc created	23.8% · No. 1	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Indiana's 16-0 season was not a record-only outlier: the offense ranked No.2 opponent-adjusted, No.1 in EPA/play, No.2 in success rate and No.1 on third down; the defense ranked No.3 adjusted, top five in EPA/success rate, No.6 preventing explosives and No.1 creating havoc. The only relative soft spot was offensive explosiveness at No.21, still very good.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Curt Cignetti - returning	● ↔ Stable program identity buffers major roster turnover
OC / play-caller	Mike Shanahan - returning	● ↔ Same caller and structure ease the QB/skill transition
DC	Bryant Haines - returning	● ↔ Same defensive architecture; game-day caller is not separately established

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Josh Hoover	TCU	● ↔ Established projected QB1 and Maxwell watchlist signal, but replacing the No.1 overall NFL pick prevents a clear upgrade label.
◆ WR Nick Marsh	Michigan State	● ↑ Brings 100 catches, 1,311 yards and nine TD over two prior seasons into a room replacing two drafted stars.
◆ OL Joe Brunner	Wisconsin	● ↔ Starter candidate who adds high-level line depth/flexibility but remains part of an unresolved alignment.
◆ TE Brock Schott	Miami	● ↔ Material TE addition after TE Riley Nowakowski's departure; role quality is more projection than proven replacement.

Out	To	Loss
QB Fernando Mendoza	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 1, No. 1	● ↓ No.1 overall pick and 2025 quarterback centerpiece is the largest offensive loss.
WR Omar Cooper Jr.	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 1, No. 30	● ↓ First-round receiver departure removes proven top-end production.
WR Elijah Sarratt	NFL (Baltimore), Round 4, No. 115	● ↓ Fourth-round receiver loss compounds the WR Omar Cooper Jr. departure despite WR Charlie Becker/WR Nick Marsh quality.
RB Kaelon Black	NFL (San Francisco), Round 3, No. 90	● ↓ Major 2025 back leaves; current RB room has recognition but less proven production.
TE Riley Nowakowski	NFL (Pittsburgh), Round 5, No. 169	● ↓ Material TE departure creates an immediate replacement role for TE Brock Schott/new depth.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Down from 2025's historic efficiency, but still top-20 caliber on personnel/structure

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ CB A.J. Harris	Penn State	● ↑ Major secondary addition projected into a starting role after first-round CB attrition.
◆ S Preston Zachman	Wisconsin	● ↑ Experienced safety integrated beside S Amare Ferrell; important replacement for two NFL-bound safeties.
◆ DL Chiddi Obiazor	Kansas State	● ↔ Material front reinforcement after EDGE Mikail Kamara's departure.
◆ DL Tobi Osunsanmi	Kansas State	● ↔ Additional material front depth; not treated as a proven one-for-one replacement for NFL production.

Out	To	Loss
CB D'Angelo Ponds	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 2, No. 50	● ↓ Second-round corner departure is the largest secondary loss.
LB Aiden Fisher	NFL (Houston), Round 7, No. 243	● ↓ Defensive leader leaves, though LB Rolijah Hardy/LB Isaiah Jones keep the unit elite.
EDGE Mikail Kamara	NFL (San Francisco 49ers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Starting edge departure reduces proven pass-rush continuity.
S Devan Boykin	NFL (Pittsburgh Steelers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Another starting safety loss raises communication/replacement demands in a disguise-heavy defense.
S Louis Moore	NFL (Miami Dolphins), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 88-tackle, six-interception safety departure compounds back-end turnover.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Down modestly from an elite 2025 unit, but still top-10 caliber because the LB/DT spine and Haines system remain strong

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Balanced, multiple-presentation offense built on plays-off-plays and disguising intent without overcomplicating assignments.	Strong OL spine, QB Josh Hoover, WR Charlie Becker/WR Nick Marsh and enough RB depth to stay balanced.	Replacing the extraordinary efficiency of QB Fernando Mendoza plus multiple drafted skill players.
Defense	Bryant Haines' 'illusion defense' uses post-snap movement, twists, disguise and opponent-specific pressure/coverage answers.	LB Rolijah Hardy/LB Isaiah Jones at linebacker, DL Tyrique Tucker up front and S Amare Ferrell in the secondary.	Communication and disruption must survive major pro losses at CB, safety, edge and LB.
Special teams	Strong returning kicker with turnover at punter and long snapper.	K Nico Radicic's established role and Lou Groza recognition.	Replacing P Mitch McCarthy/LS Mark Langston in the operation.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	QB Josh Hoover is the projected starter, but he replaces No.1 overall pick QB Fernando Mendoza.
RB	● B	● ↓	Medium	Turbo Richard and Khobie Martin both carry Doak Walker recognition, but RB Kaelon Black and RB Roman Hemby are professional departures.
WR	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	WR Charlie Becker is a high-end returner and WR Nick Marsh brings proven production.
TE	● B-	● ↓	Medium	Incoming TE Brock Schott is material, but TE Riley Nowakowski's NFL draft departure removes the proven 2025 benchmark.
OL	● A-	● ↔	Medium-high	OT Carter Smith, OL Bray Lynch and OL Drew Evans form a high-end core with OL Joe Brunner competing.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium	DL Tyrique Tucker is an All-America-level anchor with material transfer reinforcement.
LB	● A	● ↔	High	LB Rolijah Hardy and LB Isaiah Jones provide elite continuity after LB Aiden Fisher's draft departure.
Secondary	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	S Amare Ferrell returns and S Preston Zachman/CB A.J. Harris add talent after major professional departures.
Special teams	● B	● ↓	Medium	K Nico Radicic is a returning Groza watchlist kicker.
Coaching	● A	● ↔	High	Cignetti, Shanahan and Haines retain the core system; Shanahan is the offensive play caller and Sunseri returns as co-OC/QB coach.
Overall	● A	● ↓	Medium-high	SP+ No.5/AP No.6 and elite returning trench/linebacker pieces keep Indiana top-10 caliber despite major NFL attrition.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Carter Smith	OT	● National star / elite tackle	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 1st team · Outland	Highest-confidence anchor of an OL that can insulate a new QB and preserve Indiana's offensive identity.
Tyrique Tucker	DL	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP 2nd team · Walter Camp 1st team · Big Ten preseason · Bednarik · Outland · Walter Camp POY	Elite recognition and front presence are critical after Mikail Kamara's professional departure.
Rolijah Hardy	LB	● National star / defensive leader	AP 1st team · Walter Camp 2nd team · Big Ten preseason · Bednarik · Bronko Nagurski · Butkus	Returning starter and centerpiece of the defense's strongest continuity unit.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Charlie Becker	WR	● Nationally recognized high-end target	AP 2nd team · Big Ten preseason · Biletnikoff · Walter Camp POY	Started eight of final nine games in 2025 and becomes a primary continuity piece for Hoover.
◆ Josh Hoover (TR: TCU)	QB	● High-end Power 4 starter projection	Maxwell	Established projected QB1 replacing No.1 overall pick Fernando Mendoza; his assimilation sets Indiana's offensive ceiling.
Isaiah Jones	LB	● High-end national/conference starter	Walter Camp 2nd team · Bednarik · Bronko Nagurski · Butkus	Pairs with Hardy to keep the second level elite after Aiden Fisher's departure.
Amare Ferrell	S	● High-end conference starter / secondary leader	Bronko Nagurski · Jim Thorpe	41 career games, 28 starts and 15 starts in 2025 make him the communication anchor for a rebuilt secondary.
◆ Nick Marsh (TR: Michigan State)	WR	● High-upside Power 4 starter	-	100 catches, 1,311 yards and nine touchdowns over two seasons give Indiana a proven transfer answer to major WR losses.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Challenging enough to test a title defense but favorable for a top-five team: four home games to open, then the defining three-game run at Nebraska/Ohio State/at Michigan, with a bye before the late USC-Washington sequence.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Difficult · SP+ SOS No. 32
Hardest stretch	at Nebraska -> Ohio State -> at Michigan
Swing games	Ohio State, at Michigan
Advantage	The first four games are at home, and the Nov. 7 bye falls immediately before USC.
Expected	10.0 wins · most likely 10-2
Floor / ceiling	9-3 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Elite-team pricing is justified by AP No. 6/SP+ No. 5, but heavy NFL attrition creates early uncertainty.
Back them when	The price overweights turnover relative to the retained coaching/OL/LB structure.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay an elite premium before QB Josh Hoover and the new skill/secondary pieces prove their efficiency.
Key monitor	QB Josh Hoover efficiency and WR Charlie Becker/WR Nick Marsh chemistry, final OL five, EDGE Stephen Daley workload, secondary integration and specialists.
Week 1 baseline	vs. North Texas: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Indiana -40.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Indiana still has a top-five profile because HC Curt Cignetti's system, an elite OL/LB spine and strong defensive structure survived an enormous professional departure class. QB Josh Hoover now has to replace the efficiency and stability QB Fernando Mendoza gave the offense.

The defense should remain high-end, but the secondary and pass-game replacements introduce more variance than last season. The schedule gives Indiana a real title-defense path while making the Nebraska-Ohio State-Michigan stretch the clearest measure of whether the reload is championship-level.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [fall camp](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [position/camp update](#) · ['Decent Start' Expectations High as](#) · [Preseason Central Football 2026](#) · [Notebook](#)
[Winning Blueprint Offensive line](#) · [Indiana 2026 NFL draft picks](#)

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